



Dog Story.

by Rob John.

I must have been eleven when this thing with the dog happened. I'm nearly twenty now but I can remember everything like it was yesterday.

It was the day before my birthday and I was coming home from school... on the train.

I'd only just started at the big school. I had a new uniform and new teachers and new stuff to learn but the biggest change for me was I had to travel to school every day by train...by myself. I liked going to school on the train. Made me feel sort of...you know...grown up.

Anyway on this particular day, the day before my birthday, I was coming home from school and I sat down in a carriage opposite an old lady with a dog. It was a small, white, scruffy-looking dog but there was something about it I really liked. I remember thinking if I ever had a dog I'd want one like this.

I looked at the old lady and she smiled at me. I smiled back then I looked down at the little white dog...and he smiled at me too! I stared at the dog and the dog stared at me then he lay down, put his head on the old lady's foot, looked up at me and winked. I know what you're thinking. Dogs can't smile and wink. But this one could.

Next thing I knew we'd stopped at a station. The old lady smiled at me again, stood up and got off the train. I watched her walk along the platform before I realised she'd got off without her dog! The dog was still in the carriage! I banged on the window and shouted:

'Hey. You forgot your dog. You left your dog behind.'
The old lady smiled, waved at me and then walked off

I didn't know what to do. I thought maybe I should tell the ticket collector when he came round but it felt kind of nice sitting there with a dog resting his head on my foot. I liked the feeling.

At the next stop the carriage started to fill up and lots of people noticed the dog. When they saw him they all sort of smiled. He was that sort of dog. When you looked at him he made you want to smile.

Then he started doing tricks. Nothing fancy at first. Just standing on his back legs and holding out his paw. But it got people looking at him laughing. I mean it's not every day you see a dog doing tricks on a train. Then,



when he was sure everyone was watching, he really went for it. He stood up on his back legs and then suddenly jumped in the air and spun head over heels. Next he hopped around on one front paw, then he did a couple of flying back flips and finished standing on his head while barking the tune to God Save the Queen.

'He's amazing,' said a little boy. 'How long have you had him?'

'Not long,' I said...which was sort of true.

'What's his name?' said someone else.

I was about to say. 'I don't know. He's not really mine,' but instead I said, 'Bob. His name's Bob.'

I don't know why I said that but suddenly everyone on the train was going, 'Come on Bob do some more tricks.'

Soon other passengers were crowding into our carriage to see the show. Well, there was no stopping Bob now. Turned out he knew quite a few songs and was a pretty good tap dancer too. By the time we got to my station the whole carriage was cheering.

As soon as the train came to a stop Bob jumped off the train, raced down the platform and disappeared. I searched the station for him but he'd just vanished. I walked home feeling really sad. Like I'd been given something very special then somehow lost it.

Then, as I turned the round the corner into my road, I looked up and there he was. Bob. Sitting on the pavement...right outside my house... waiting for me.

'How did you get here?' I said. 'How did you know where I...?'

The front door of the house was open and Bob raced up the garden path and straight into the house like he'd lived there all his life.

Soon as she saw his smile and a few of his tricks my Mum fell in love with Bob.

'Can I keep him Mum?' I said.

'Course you can,' she said.

That night as I went to sleep with Bob curled up snoring at the foot of my bed I was happiest girl in the world.

Next thing I knew it was morning and my Mum was singing 'Happy birthday to you. Happy birthday...'

I sat up in bed. There was no sign of Bob and I realised that the whole thing had been a dream. The train, the old lady, the little white dog, the tricks, the cheering crowds...all just a dream. I don't think I'd ever felt so disappointed.

'Cheer up! It's your birthday,' said Mum. 'Here open this one first.'

She put cardboard box covered in round holes on my bed. I didn't really

feel like presents but I opened this box and inside, fast asleep was a puppy. A small, white, scruffy-looking puppy.

'Is he mine?' I said.

'Yes love,' said Mum. 'What're you going to call him?'

I looked into the box and said, 'Hello Bob.'

The puppy woke up and opened one eye.

'Look,' said Mum. 'He's winking at you.'

I've still got Bob. He's quite old now. I never managed to teach him one single trick but sometimes when he's fast asleep and chasing rabbits in his dreams I swear you can see him smiling.